YOUR FIRST 28 DAYS

CLEAN FOR TODAY

From people who've sat where you're sitting.



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FOREWORD

From Dave B.

If you're holding this, you just walked through a door you probably swore you'd never walk through. Maybe somebody drove you. Maybe a judge sent you. Maybe you came on your own. However you got here, you're here. That was the hardest part, and you already did it.

I've sat where you're sitting. Six times. It took me six inpatient rehabs, two overdoses that almost killed me, and a prison sentence. The first five times, I thought I was the exception. Three of those times, I walked out before it was over. My addiction had a story for every occasion, and I believed every one.

The sixth time, I came in from a tent along the highway in Oregon. I'd lost custody of my son, my marriage, my career, and every dollar I'd ever made. The rehab didn't change the sixth time. I did. I stopped doing it my way, and I let people help me.

That's all this booklet asks of you. One page a day. Some days it'll land. Some days it won't. Read it anyway.

There will be a day when every part of you wants to walk out. The disease will make it sound reasonable. *You're fine*

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now. This place isn't for people like you. I know that voice. Before you go, turn to **Before You Walk Out** and tell somebody what you're thinking. The whisper loses its power in daylight.

You don't need a wild story. You don't have to believe in God. You don't have to be ready. You just have to stay through today. If it worked for someone like me, it can work for you.

Stay. We'll be here tomorrow.
— Dave B.

HOW TO USE THIS

Before You Start

No catching up required. If a page calls to you, skip ahead. If you leave before Day 28, take it with you.

If you take medication for addiction as prescribed, you're in recovery. That's clean time. Nobody in any room gets to tell you otherwise.

If a feeling includes wanting to die or hurt yourself, that is an emergency. Tell staff now, or call or text 988.

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IF YOU’RE THINKING ABOUT LEAVING

Before You Walk Out

Every one of us had this night. The bag half packed. The reasons lined up. *I'm fine now. This place is a joke. I'll do it on my own.* That's not you talking. That's the disease, and it's scared, because you're winning.

Before you go, do three things:

1. **Wait one hour.** Cravings and panic rise and fall. Set a clock.
2. **Tell a person.** A counselor, a nurse, the person in the next bed. Say: "I'm thinking about leaving." That sentence is enough. Whatever is pushing you out the door, it may be fixable.
3. **Read Day 7 and Day 12.** Then decide.

If you still leave, we want you alive to come back. The door doesn't lock behind you.

- **Detoxing from alcohol or pills like Xanax or Klonopin?** Tell the nurse before you go. Stopping those suddenly can cause seizures and death.
- **On medication for addiction?** Ask for a bridge prescription before you leave.
- **Sent by a court?** Ask what leaving means for your case.
- **Your tolerance is lower than you think.** Your body has already changed. The amount you used to use can kill you now.
- **Assume there's fentanyl in it.** Use test strips if you can get them.
- **Don't use alone. Carry naloxone (Narcan).** Ask staff for some on your way out. If someone overdoses: give Narcan, call 911, and give a second dose if they don't wake up in 2–3 minutes.
- **Call before you use.** Never Use Alone: 800-484-3731. They stay on the line and send help if you stop answering.
- **Talk to someone.** 988 (call or text), or SAMHSA's National Helpline, 1-800-662-4357 — free, confidential, 24/7, English and Spanish.
- **Come back.** Call this facility at _____. Being readmitted is not failure. It took Dave six tries.

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DAY 1

Gloves Down

Nobody walks into recovery proud. We get here beat — out of tricks, out of excuses, out of people who still believe us. And that's the good news. Admitting we're powerless over our addiction isn't losing the fight. It's finally admitting the fight was rigged. For years we kept swinging at something that never got tired, never slept, never missed a chance. Today we get to set the gloves down. We don't have to win. We just have to quit lying about who's been winning. That honesty feels like defeat at first. It isn't. It's the first solid ground we've stood on in a long time. For today, we don't have to beat it. We just have to tell the truth about it — and stay clean while we do.

Watch Day 1

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DAY 2

Forever Is Too Heavy

The disease loves big numbers. Never again. The rest of your life. Forever. It hands us forever like a weight we were never built to lift, then laughs when we drop it. We don't carry forever. We carry today. Today has edges. It has a morning and a night and a pillow at the end. We can stay clean from here to that pillow. Nobody in the rooms got years by staring at years. They got them the same way we're getting this one — one day stacked on another, most of them ordinary, some of them ugly, every one of them enough. So put forever down. It was never ours to hold. Pick up today. It fits in your hands.

Watch Day 2

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DAY 3

The Chair

Somewhere tonight there's a folding chair with nobody in it yet. A warm cup of coffee, a few friendly faces, a room that smells like second chances. We used to think we were too smart for rooms like that. Too different. Too far gone, or not far gone enough. Then we sat down, and somebody said out loud the thing we'd never told anyone — and it was our story in a stranger's mouth. That's the miracle nobody advertises. Not the speeches. The recognition. The moment we realize we were never as alone as the disease told us. The chair's still there. It doesn't care what we did. It only asks one thing. Sit down. Keep coming back.

Watch Day 3

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DAY 4

The Longest Hallway

It's maybe forty steps from your bed to the nurses' station. Except at three in the morning, when the craving hits. Then it's a mile. Funny how that works. We'd walk across town in the rain to cop without a second thought, but walking down a hallway to ask for help feels like climbing a mountain. That's not weakness talking. That's the disease, protecting itself. It knows that walk can kill it. So we walk it anyway. We don't need the right words. "Hey, it's me, I'm having a day" is a whole sentence. Whoever's on shift has seen this before, and they'd rather you knock than leave. Take the walk. It gets shorter every time.

Watch Day 4

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DAY 5

Clean Isn't Numb

Nobody warned us about this part. We put the drugs down, and the feelings showed up all at once, like they'd been waiting in the parking lot for years. Anger with nowhere to go. Grief we skipped. Joy so sharp it almost hurts. For a long time we kept all of it at arm's length. Now there's no arm. Here's what the people with time will tell us: feelings aren't facts, and they aren't emergencies. They pass. Every single one of them passes, if we don't use over it. But if a feeling includes wanting to die or hurt yourself, that is an emergency. Tell staff now, or call or text 988. This is what being alive feels like — loud, messy, and ours. We're not broken because it hurts. We're healing because we can finally feel it.

Watch Day 5

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DAY 6

Small Things

Recovery doesn't usually look like a movie. No swelling strings, no sunrise on a mountaintop. Mostly it looks like a made bed. A paycheck that goes where it's supposed to. A promise kept on a Tuesday when nobody's watching. We used to chase big. Big highs, big plans, big comebacks we never came back from. Now the miracle is small and quiet, and it shows up every day. Showing up on time. Answering the phone. Looking someone in the eye. Don't skip the small things. They're not the warm-up to recovery. They are recovery. Stack enough of them together, and one day you look up and realize you've built a life.

Watch Day 6

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DAY 7

Still Here

If you're reading this, you're still here. Don't rush past that. Some of us didn't make it. We carry their names. And every morning we wake up clean, we're doing something they didn't get the chance to do. That's not guilt. That's purpose. And if yesterday went sideways — if you used, if you ran, if you're reading this from the bottom again — the door didn't lock behind you. It never does. Nobody in the rooms is keeping score. We're just glad you came back. Today is new. It doesn't know what you did. It only knows you're here. So let's start there. Together.

Watch Day 7

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DAY 8

Wreckage

Powerless is only half of it. The other half is what our lives looked like while we pretended we were in charge. Missed rent. Missed birthdays. Phones we were afraid to answer. We called it bad luck. We called it a rough patch. We called it anything but what it was. Unmanageable isn't an insult. It's an accurate description. And there's a strange relief in finally saying it out loud — no spin, no excuses, no story about how it wasn't that bad. Once we stop defending the wreckage, we can start clearing it. One piece at a time. Starting with today.

Watch Day 8

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DAY 9

Hope

Hope is a dangerous word when it's lied to you a hundred times. This time will be different. This time I've got it handled. So when someone says there's a power that can restore us to sanity, it's fair to squint. Here's the thing, though. We don't have to believe it all at once. We just have to look around the room. People who were worse off than us are laughing. Holding jobs. Raising kids. Something worked for them that never worked when they tried it alone. Call it the group. Call it whatever you want. We don't need a definition. We just need to be willing to believe it might work for us too.

Watch Day 9

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DAY 10

Letting Go

We are experts at holding on. Holding grudges, holding secrets, holding the steering wheel with both fists while the car goes straight into the ditch. Letting go sounds like giving up. It feels like falling. But look at what our grip has actually gotten us. Letting go doesn't mean we stop caring or stop trying. It means we stop running the whole show on our own broken judgment. We make a decision, and then we make it again tomorrow, and the day after that. Our hands were never built to hold this much. Open them. See what lands.

Watch Day 10

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DAY 11

Just One

It usually shows up as a whisper. Just one. Just this weekend. Just to take the edge off. The disease is patient. It doesn't need us to use today. It just needs us to keep a little door open in the back of our minds — a reservation, a someday, a special occasion. That door is how a lot of us went back to the bottom. So we close it out loud. We tell someone about the whisper the moment we hear it. Secrets keep it alive. Saying it in daylight takes away its voice. There is no "just one" for us. There's just today, clean.

Watch Day 11

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DAY 12

It Passes

A craving feels like it will last forever. It feels like a wall we can't get around, a noise that won't stop until we feed it. Our disease lies about that, too. Cravings rise, crest, and fall — every single one, as long as we don't use over it. So we ride it out. We tell someone. We eat something. We go to group, take a walk, take a shower, pray if we pray. We do anything except the one thing. And an hour later, we notice it's gone, and we're still standing. That's a win. Count it.

Watch Day 12

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DAY 13

Open Mind

We came in knowing everything. We knew what would work, what wouldn't, and why the people in here were different from us. Then we looked around. People whose whole job is helping us get well. People in the next bed who've been exactly where we are. Plenty of people who need this never get the chance. Maybe it's time to let somebody else's experience in. An open mind doesn't mean we believe everything. It means we stop arguing long enough to listen. Some of us say clean. Some of us say sober. It's the same road. And if you take medication for addiction as prescribed, that's clean time too. We try the suggestion before we decide it won't work. We let the person who's been here longer finish the sentence. Some of the best things in recovery came wrapped in advice we almost ignored.

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DAY 14

Willing

We don't have to be ready. We don't have to be sure. Most of us weren't. What we needed was much smaller than that. A little willingness. A crack in the door. Enough to show up one more time, make one more call, try one more thing we swore we'd never do. Willingness isn't a feeling. It's an action. We do it scared. We do it tired. We do it while the voice in our head says this won't work. And somewhere in the doing, the feeling catches up. Enough showing up starts to look a lot like faith from the outside. It is.

Watch Day 14

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DAY 15

Halt

Hungry. Angry. Lonely. Tired. Four ordinary things, and every one of them can make a perfectly good day feel like an emergency. We used to think we used because life was unbearable. A lot of the time, we'd just skipped lunch and slept four hours. So before we decide the whole world is falling apart, we check the basics. Eat something. Breathe first. Talk to somebody. Lie down. Recovery isn't always deep. Sometimes it's a sandwich and a nap.

Watch Day 15

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DAY 16

The Tape

We replay it. What they said, what they did, what we should have said back. We've run the tape so many times we know every word. Resentment feels like justice. It feels like keeping score for the good guys. But the person we're angry at usually isn't losing any sleep. We are. We're the ones swallowing the poison and waiting for them to get sick. So try something different. Play the tape forward. Where does this one end if we keep running it? For a lot of us, it ends with using. We don't have to pretend it didn't happen. We just have to ask what our part was, and what we're willing to set down. If someone abused you, you had no part in that. Talk it through with a counselor or sponsor. Write it out. Let it out of the dark. Freedom is worth more than being right.

Watch Day 16

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DAY 17

Fear

Fear has been driving a lot longer than we've been clean. Fear of being found out. Fear of being alone. Fear that this is all we'll ever be. For years we used to keep it quiet. Now it's loud again, and nothing is muffling it. Here's what we learn: fear is a feeling, not a forecast. It tells us a lot about our past and almost nothing true about tomorrow. Courage isn't the absence of fear. It's doing the next right thing with our hands still shaking. We don't need to beat fear today. We just keep it in the passenger seat, not behind the wheel.

> If a feeling includes wanting to die or hurt yourself, that is an emergency. Tell staff now, or call or text 988.

Watch Day 17

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DAY 18

The Coffee

Somebody had to make the coffee. Somebody unlocked the door, set out the chairs, and stayed late to stack them again. For a long time, we never wondered who that somebody was. Then one night, someone handed us the keys. Service sounds like a big word, but it's mostly small things. Greeting the newcomer. Washing the pot. Giving someone a ride. And here's what nobody tells you: it's not really for them. When we're busy being useful, there's less room for the self-obsession that kept us sick. You don't have to wait until you leave. Stack the chairs after group. Wipe down the table. Say hi to the next person who walks in scared. When you get out, find a home group and grab a job. Any job. It's the easiest way to stay.

Watch Day 18

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DAY 19

Alone

Isolation doesn't feel dangerous. It feels like rest. Like staying in your room tonight, skipping group, not answering when someone knocks. That's exactly how it gets in. The disease does its best work when we're alone with it, in a quiet room, with nobody asking how we're really doing. The cure is almost embarrassingly simple. Other people. One conversation in the hallway. One chair in group, next to one other addict. We don't have to like it. We don't have to say much. We just have to show up where we can be seen. We stay clean together.

Watch Day 19



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DAY 20

Old Roads

Some roads will still pull at us when we leave. The old neighborhood. The old number still saved in the phone. The friend who's doing fine and just wants to hang out like old times. We'll tell ourselves we're strong enough now. That we can just visit. Here's a question worth asking before you go: why would we want to? Changing people, places, and things isn't punishment. It's protection. We delete the number. We take a different way home. We find new people who'll call us on our birthday, clean. Some of those losses hurt. But the road behind us has already shown us exactly where it goes.

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DAY 21

Progress

We wanted to be fixed by now. The anger gone, the patience perfect, the old habits erased. Then we snapped at someone in the med line and decided we were doing recovery wrong. Hold on. A while back, would we even have noticed? Would we have apologized? Would we have stayed clean through it? We're not aiming for perfect. We're aiming for a little better than yesterday, and honest about where we fell short. Progress is slow, and quiet, and real. Look how far you've already walked.

Watch Day 21



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DAY 22

Shame

Guilt says, I did something bad. Shame says, I am something bad. Shame is the one that kept us using. It told us we were too far gone, too damaged, too much to fix — so why bother trying? And shame loves the dark. It grows in secrets. It shrinks the moment we say it out loud to someone who doesn't flinch. That's what group is for, and the rooms after that. We tell the truth, and someone nods, because they did it too. We are not the worst thing we ever did. We're people with a disease, getting better. You can put the shame down. It was never yours to carry.

Watch Day 22



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DAY 23

The Mirror

We're good at taking other people's inventory. What they did wrong. Why they're the problem. We could write books about everybody else. Eventually, recovery hands us a pencil and asks us to write about ourselves. That's terrifying, because we know what's in there. Or we think we do. Here's what most of us found: the list was shorter than we feared, and full of the same things everyone else had. Fear. Selfishness. Hurt. Not monsters. People. An honest look in the mirror isn't punishment. It's finally seeing clearly enough to change. Do it with a counselor or sponsor. Not alone.

Watch Day 23

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DAY 24

The Plan

Discharge day feels like the finish line. It isn't. It's the starting line, and the first few days out are when a lot of us went back. Not because we wanted to. Because we walked out with no plan, and the old life had one waiting for us. So we build ours before we leave. Where are we sleeping the first night? Who's picking us up? Where's the first meeting, and what time does it start? Whose numbers are in the phone? When is the first appointment with a counselor? Write it down. Go over it with your counselor or sponsor. A plan won't make us feel ready. It doesn't have to. It just has to be there when the feeling isn't. Today, we start writing ours.

Watch Day 24

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DAY 25

Earning It Back

When we get out, a lot of us expect the world to throw a parade. Instead, our family may still check our eyes. Still count the money. Still flinch when the phone rings late. That hurts. And it's fair. We spent years teaching them not to trust us. It's going to take more than a few good weeks to teach them something new. So we stop demanding trust and start earning it. Quietly. Consistently. Day after day, until our actions say what our words never could. Their healing runs on its own clock, not ours. Our job isn't to rush them. Our job is to keep showing up, clean.

Watch Day 25

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DAY 26

Saturday Night

Nobody warns us about Saturday nights after treatment. In here, every hour has a schedule. Out there, the week ends, the phone goes quiet, and suddenly there's a whole evening with nothing in it. Boredom used to be our cue. The old life was a lot of things, but it was never boring — and the disease is happy to remind us. So before we leave, we plan the weekend like it matters, because it does. A meeting, then coffee with whoever's still in the parking lot. A movie. A long ride. The thing we always said we'd learn. Clean fun is a skill, and like any skill, it's awkward at first. Then one night you realize you laughed until midnight and never once thought about using.

Watch Day 26

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DAY 27

Grateful Anyway

Some days are just hard. Detox drags. The food is bad. Somebody we love won't call back. And on those days, someone in group says they're grateful, and we want to tell them exactly where they can shove their gratitude. But gratitude isn't pretending the bad stuff isn't happening. It's noticing what's still standing in the middle of it. A bed. A counselor down the hall. A number you'll take with you. A day where the worst thing that happened was bad, and we didn't make it worse. Write three things down tonight. Small ones count. Especially small ones. Gratitude on a bad day is the strongest kind.

Watch Day 27

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DAY 28

Pass It On

Somebody did this for us. Somebody told the truth in a room we almost didn't walk into. For a while, we sat in the back and said nothing. Listening felt like enough. It wasn't. When we keep quiet, nobody knows what we're carrying, and nobody can help us carry it. There's an old saying in recovery: we can't keep what we have unless we give it away. Here's what it means. Recovery we keep to ourselves starts to fade. Recovery we say out loud stays real. So raise your hand. Not a speech. Just a quick check-in: here's where I'm at today. It isn't for them. It's for us.

Watch Day 28

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SERIES SIGN-OFF

“That's today. Stay clean through it. We'll be here tomorrow.”

All 28 days

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